

Accenture and CereProc create 'Sam', an open source non-binary voice solution

Accenture has collaborated with CereProc, a text-to-speech technology provider, to create Sam, a non-binary voice solution for the fast-growing global digital assistant market. To encourage adoption, the companies have released all the materials used to generate the voice to the open source community.

This year, consumers interacted with 4.2 billion digital voice assistants around the world, and that number is expected to double to 8.4 billion devices by 2024, according to a report by Juniper Research. The vast majority of today's device voices are female, or female by default, and this limited diversity is problematic.

A 2019 UNESCO report found that designing female-only voice assistants reinforces gender bias and encourages negative behaviour, both with digital assistants and with real people. Additionally, voices available today are binary and do not reflect the transgender or gender non-conforming community, which represents 12 per cent of millennials.

To help solve these issues, researchers at Accenture Labs worked closely with members of the non-binary community on the development of Sam's voice. Accenture surveyed non-binary individuals and used their feedback and audio data to influence not only pitch, but speech patterns, intonation, and word choice. CereProc then created the text-to-speech model using its artificial intelligence (AI) technology. The result is a voice that combines aspects of male and female voices to better resonate with the community it was designed to represent.

million open source components across dozens of ecosystems, the Nexus Platform identifies open source risk and provides expert remediation guidance. It also helps to innovate faster.

Pradeep Govindasamy, CTO and president, Cigniti Technologies, said, "As experts in continuous delivery, Cigniti has worked hard to help its customers implement a mature DevSec pipeline. As such, many of our global customers have enquired about software composition analysis to help protect their toolchains. Partnering with Sonatype, who has the in-depth, precise intelligence around open source vulnerabilities, allows us to offer an ever-deeper sense of security to our customers. There is a clear synergy between Sonatype and Cigniti to create a successful partnership."

Wai Man Yau, general manager international, Sonatype, said, "Sonatype has been working with global enterprise customers for over a decade to identify and mitigate millions of security vulnerabilities and protect their software supply.



Image Source: rawpixel.com

Through our partnership with Cigniti, we'll be able to further enhance DevSecOps in new regions, providing customers with the continued automated security features they need to build secure software."

Stacklet secures US\$ 18 million in Series A funding

Stacklet, developer of the cloud governance platform based on Cloud Custodian, has announced it has closed US\$ 18 million in Series A funding. The investment was led by Addition, with participation from Foundation Capital and new individual investor Liam Randall. The funds are earmarked for continuing the support and growth of the Cloud Custodian community, advancing the Stacklet platform, and hiring in engineering, marketing, sales and customer success.

Travis Stanfield, co-founder and CEO, Stacklet, said, "Organisations are moving to the cloud faster than we expected due to Covid-19, which has resulted in cloud governance and costs needing to be better addressed and managed. This has created an exciting opportunity for Stacklet and the Cloud Custodian community. Stacklet is committed to ensuring that Cloud Custodian provides the world's best cloud governance platform and to continuing its free distribution. We look forward to working with industry partners, and in particular the major cloud providers, to ensure its widespread adoption."